

Borges on Homeric Versions

In his essay, "The Homeric Versions," Jorge Luis Borges challenges how original texts are placed above translations. He argues that focusing on a "definitive text" is misguided, "correspond[ing] only to religion or exhaustion" (p. 15). By considering the translation process to be an "intentional game of attention" (p. 15), Borges posits that translators should be active participants in the life of a text, aligning with both Estienne Dolet and Martin Luther who believe a translator can make deliberate choices and should not only focus on a word-for-word translation.

In empowering translators, Borges's approach echoes Walter Benjamin's concept of a text's afterlife. Similar to how John Dryden looked at accessibility as a way to prevent a text from becoming obscure and not read, Borges argues that translation prevents a text from getting stuck in or lost to the past. He also argues against the idea of translations as worse than the original, stating that "to assume that every recombination of elements is necessarily inferior to its original form is to assume that draft nine is necessarily inferior to draft H--for there can only be drafts" (p. 15).

Using Homer as a case study, Borges demonstrates this theory. When considering the events written in Homer's epics, Borges notes Homer's intentions and "what he actually thought of them have all disappeared" (p. 17). He points out this actually offers "greater richness for the translator" (p. 17). Looking at different English translations by Buckley, Butcher, Lang, Cowper, Pope, and Chapman, ranging from the literal Buckley to more superlative-focused Pope, Borges views these differing translations over time as how the work grows, not just a search for the

original. By even listing them in non-chronological order, he validates his idea that translation can be rich in a variety of ways, going on to say "Which of these many translations is faithful? my reader will want to know. I repeat: none or all of them" (p. 19).